

| Assessment | Test                | Domain                       | Skill      | Difficulty                                          |
|------------|---------------------|------------------------------|------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| SAT        | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium <div><div></div><div></div><div></div></div> |

Question

In ancient Greece, an Epicurean was a follower of Epicurus, a philosopher whose beliefs revolved around the pursuit of pleasure. Epicurus defined pleasure as “the absence of pain in the body and of trouble in the \_\_\_\_\_ that all life’s virtues derived from this absence.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. soul,” positing
- B. soul”: positing
- C. soul”; positing
- D. soul.” Positing

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a participial phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“Epicurus...‘soul’”) and the participial phrase (“positing...absence”) that provides additional information about how Epicurus defined pleasure.

Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a participial phrase. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a participial phrase. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “positing.”